40 and did pioneering work on plant chromosomes and evolution. In 1951, now an internationally renowned scholar, she returned to India to take up a research position at Prime Minister Nehru's invitation. Among her many other contributions was the breeding of a new type of sweeter sugarcane that could be grown locally—this is still grown today!

SILENT VALLEY NATIONAL PARK

In the 1970s, the government wanted to destroy a tract of densely forested land to build a dam in a part of Kerala called the Silent Valley. However, environmental activists waged a successful, ten-year-long campaign against the dam, which threatened unique endangered species in the area. Ammal lent the weight of her expertise to show how important the valley's biodiversity was.



VIJAYA LAKSHMI PANDIT

1900–1990